In some respects, the 1990s were not the best of times for new political forces in Eastern Europe to arise from the ashes. What happened in the meantime with the party political scene in Western Europe was a significant transformation, ending the post-war consensus of Christian Democrats and Social Democrats. This consensus has produced an unparalleled social state, a state that cared for an individual from cradle to grave. The left had become less radical, perfectly respectable and politically correct. The conservative camp moved closer to the centre and away from its Christian roots. But then, the oil crisis and the slowdown of the 1990s struck. People became less interested in low-tax policies and more in keeping their jobs and preserving a generous welfare state. The left understood all this well enough, while conservatives were busy thinking how – with birth-rates at a post-war low – to finance full employment and the same levels of social benefits. Flexicurity replaced the so-called social-market economy.

And there were, as already mentioned, changes in the cultural sphere too. Increasingly, the classic liberal mindset was given less space in academia and in popular culture. A post-modern world was being born, with critical race and gender theory, the ‘woke’, presented as scientific theory and occupying the academic space. While ethnic and class issues were largely gone, new group identities in apparent need of recognition started to emerge as subjects of academic research and study, especially in the sexual sphere.

In this context, along came a newly-liberated Eastern Europe with its own economic and social problems which it was very poorly equipped to solve. Its new, mostly conservative parties not only wanted to change the whole spectrum of economic and social policies, and the fabric of society; they also wanted to address all the injustices done during the Communist regime – from annulling politically-motivated court rulings to restoring forcibly nationalised property. They wanted to compensate all the many people who had been disenfranchised by the former Communist regime. But the stakes were too high. It was much easier for the former Communists to simply adopt the appealing image and message of the contemporary European left, knowing only too well that the majority of Eastern Europeans were not primarily interested in compensation for injustices; they were more concerned about keeping their jobs and preserving relatively generous public services that were free for all. And the left did not ask for additional sacrifices from the public in order to reach the living standards and private